

The power of offloading.

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EEG during essay writing

MIT Media Lab, 2025 · 54 students

Brain only strongest connectivity

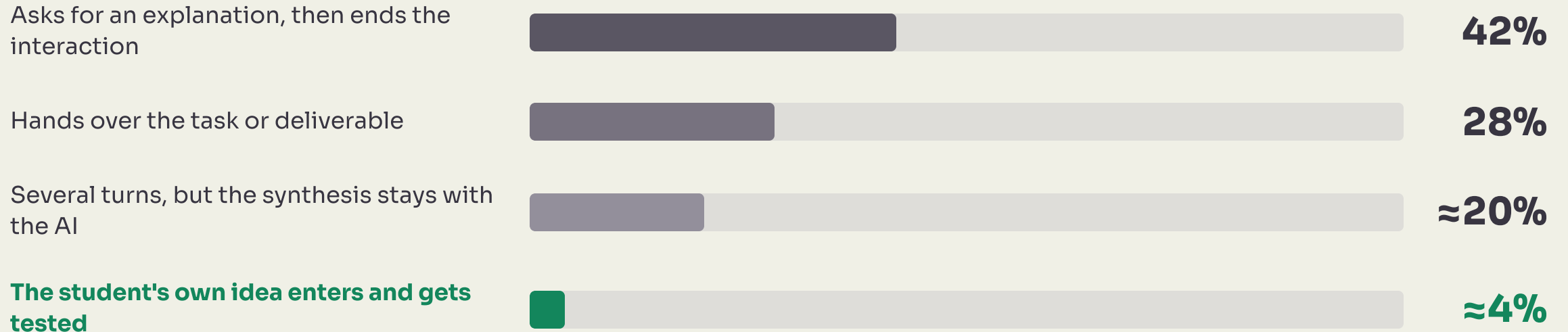
Search engine in between

LLM **weakest**

The LLM group showed weaker brain connectivity.

In search of constructive use

40,000 student messages to an AI tutor

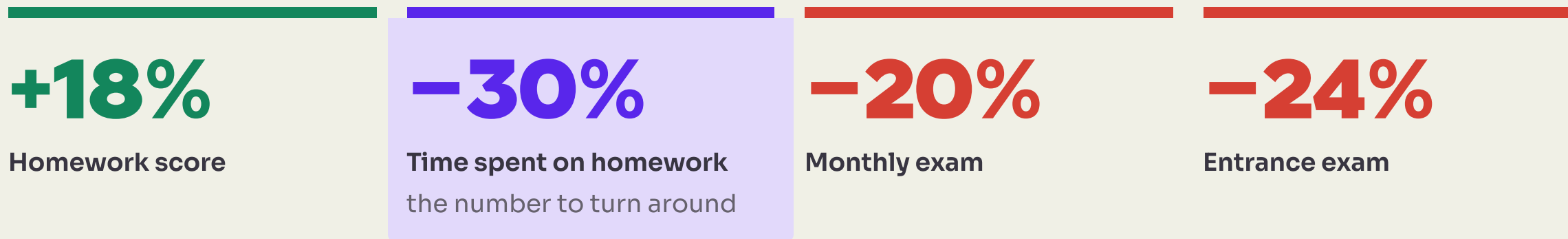


Preliminary, descriptive categorisation

Tamási, *The Power of Outsourcing*, The European Sociologist 55, 2026

Better homework, weaker exams

26,811 Chinese secondary school students, 30 months



+18%

Homework score

-30%

Time spent on homework
the number to turn around

-20%

Monthly exam

-24%

Entrance exam

Homework took less time because it could be offloaded to AI. **The exams showed it.**

Current assignments reward the result.

because until now, that was what we could see

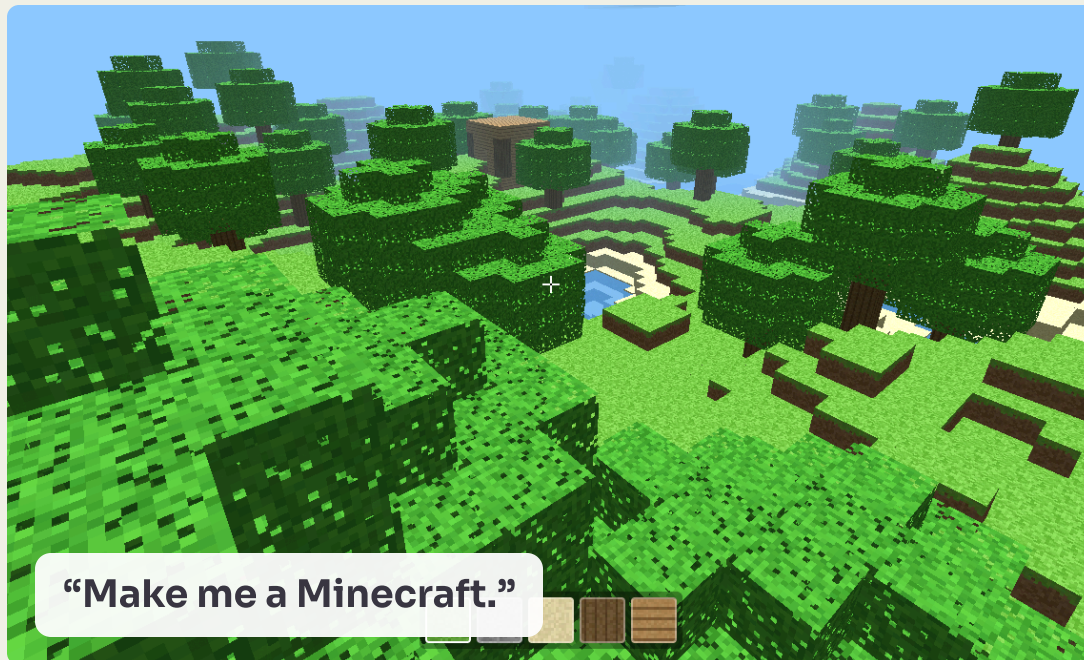
What if we rewarded the process?

Two programs, both built with AI

Vibe coding raises the floor, agentic engineering raises the ceiling.

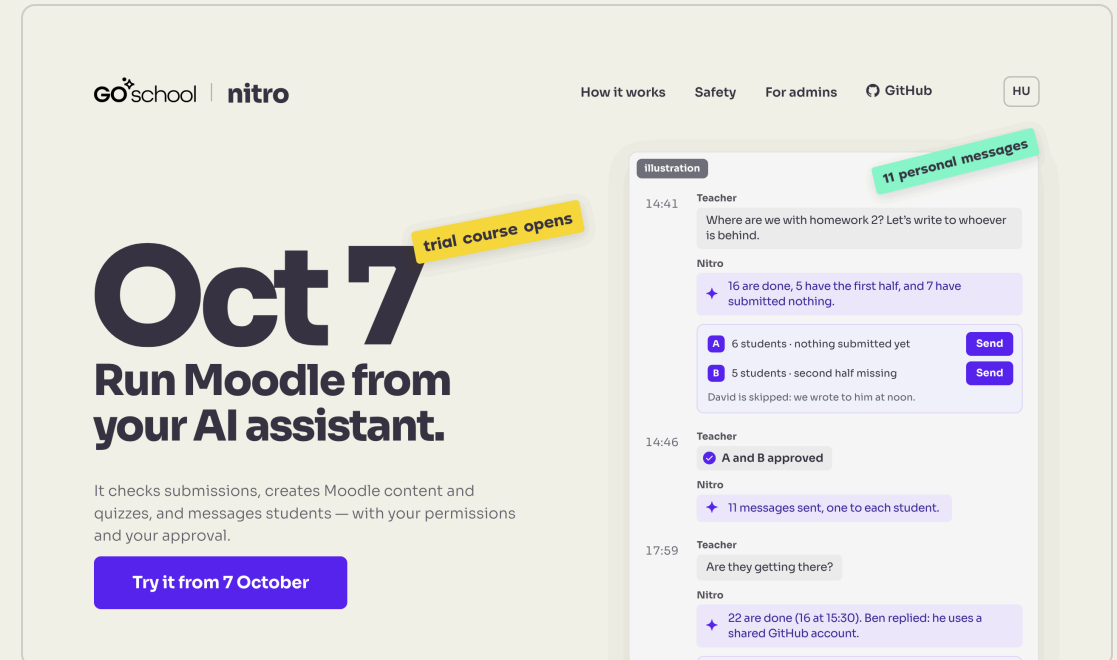
Vibe coding

a playable 3D world from one sentence



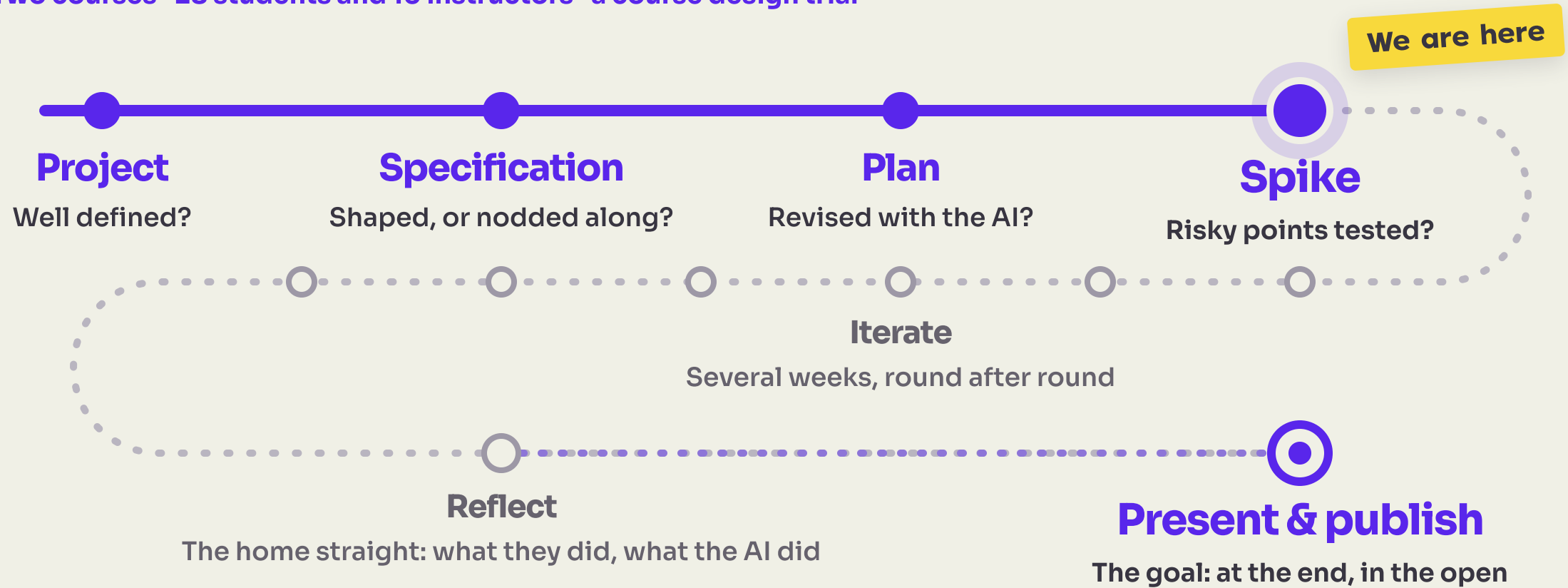
Agentic engineering

a Moodle plugin that instructors rely on



44 separate projects, worked on every week

Two courses · 28 students and 16 instructors · a course design trial

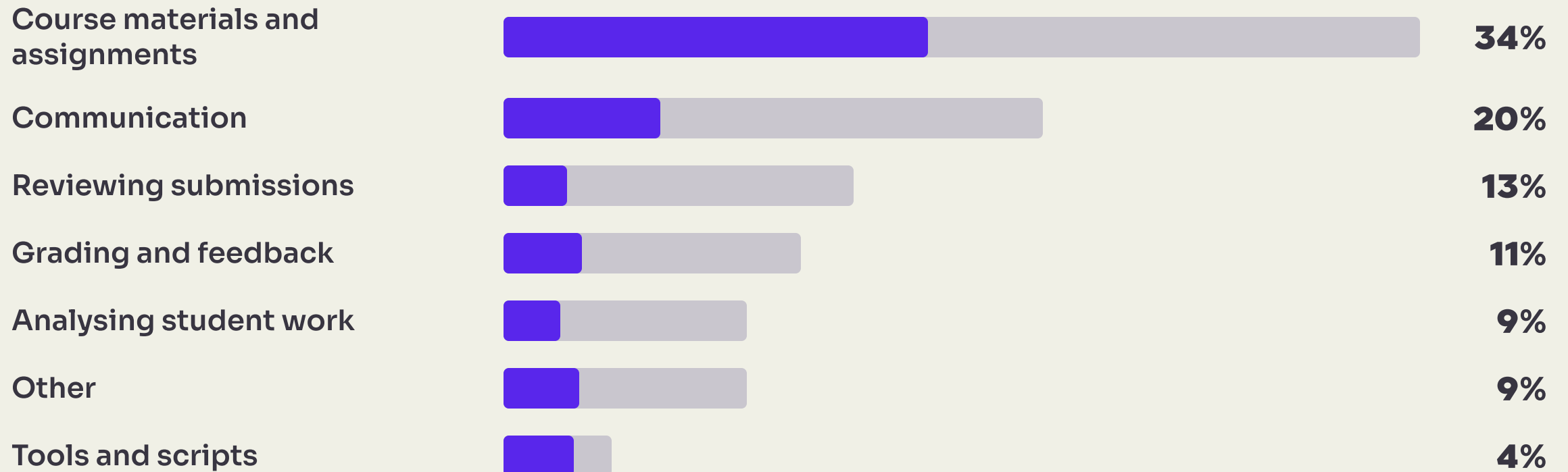


Every week, a new step on their own project. I follow it, and I support it.

Where did my time go?

My two courses, September 2026

■ my time ■ of this, the AI was working



The power of offloading, in my own work

My two courses, September 2026 - about 60 hours



15k

words I wrote

655k

words the AI read

681k

words the AI wrote

×89: for every word of mine, the AI read 44 and wrote 45.

The lesson from my courses

I accepted that they offload the coding.

They got more: real software, work they enjoy, a presentation at the end.

What stayed: control over what we create.

**“Civilization advances by
extending the number of important
operations which we can perform
without thinking about them.”**

Alfred North Whitehead

An Introduction to Mathematics, 1911

Don't fight offloading. Use its power to aim higher.

Which of your tasks could reward
the process instead of the result?



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discussion